by the Mauryas. These categories were not immutable and core areas could become independent kingdoms just as peripheral areas changed into core regions.[33]

That all administrations, ancient and modern, exercise power differently across large territories is only natural, given varying political requirements. The problem is that macro analyses using state power or economic might as their measure of all things tend to posit somewhat singular ground realities across diverse regions. From such perspectives, outlying regions come to be seen as passive providers for the metropolitan state, as also passive recipients of innovations emanating from a distant central authority. Historians employed by royalty in dominant centralizing states defined the distant regions that their masters conquered and controlled primarily in relation to the needs of the centre. Interpretations of the pre-Mughal, Mughal, and British colonial periods were also for long based on these somewhat reductive assumptions in which aspects of autonomy, subversion, and precolonial continuity in regions distant from the centre tended to be steamrolled out of existence. So also the ways in which core and periphery are described in works on ancient India which tend to overlook the peripheries of empire as the homeland of real people with their own languages, cultural predilections, and continuing everyday traditions of spirituality as well as resistance to impositions from the world beyond. The central state’s armed might was, besides, often exercised only sporadically, and sometimes restrictedly for revenue extraction, leaving many areas of activity open for local modification and variation. The fundamental point is that regions have their own local histories additional to the history of their subsumption or control by an external state, and in fact the most interesting or detailed history of a region can be more connected with aspects that make it autonomous rather than controlled. Karnataka, which Thapar sees as a periphery, seems not to have been peripheral in that broader sense; it was not remotely the passive recipient of cultural innovation from the